

Far-Right Speeches and Emotional Contagion in Parliament

Sequential and Multimodal Evidence from Germany

Christian Arnold¹ [Andreas Kuepfer](#)² Christian Stecker²

DVPW AK "Vergleichende Parlamentarismusforschung" 2026, Universität Greifswald

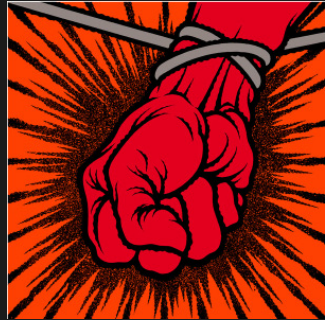
¹University of Birmingham ²Technical University of Darmstadt

How do MPs react to far-right populist parties?



"When they go low, we go high."

Michelle Obama, Democratic National Convention 2016



"I'm madly in anger with you."

Metallica, "St. Anger"

The Existing Answer: On Average, Parliaments Go High

Valentim and Widmann (2021): How do established parties react to far-right entry?

- Emotional language in parliamentary text, averaged across speeches and time
- Staggered AfD entry into German parliaments as the source of variation

The Existing Answer: On Average, Parliaments Go High

Valentim and Widmann (2021): How do established parties react to far-right entry?

- Emotional language in parliamentary text, averaged across speeches and time
- Staggered AfD entry into German parliaments as the source of variation

Their finding: rhetorical distancing

- Established parties do not become more negative.
- They respond with more positive emotional language.

The Existing Answer: On Average, Parliaments Go High

Valentim and Widmann (2021): How do established parties react to far-right entry?

- Emotional language in parliamentary text, averaged across speeches and time
- Staggered AfD entry into German parliaments as the source of variation

Their finding: rhetorical distancing

- Established parties do not become more negative.
- They respond with more positive emotional language.

So Michelle Obama wins? Only if we look at **averages** of **words**.

What the Average of Words Misses

Debate is a sequence

- Speeches answer each other within an agenda item.
- The reaction to the far right happens right after the far right speaks, not in the yearly average.

What the Average of Words Misses

Debate is a sequence

- Speeches answer each other within an agenda item.
- The reaction to the far right happens right after the far right speaks, not in the yearly average.

Emotion is multimodal

- A speech is a performed text.
- MPs communicate with words, voice, and body.

What the Average of Words Misses

Debate is a sequence

- Speeches answer each other within an agenda item.
- The reaction to the far right happens right after the far right speaks, not in the yearly average.

Emotion is multimodal

- A speech is a performed text.
- MPs communicate with words, voice, and body.

How do MPs respond to far-right speeches **right after them** and **across modalities**?

Three Mechanisms Shape the Response to Far-Right Speech

Emotional contagion: the automatic baseline

- Interaction partners mimic each other's expressions in words, face, voice, and movement.
- Mimicry preserves valence: negative begets negative, positive begets positive.

Three Mechanisms Shape the Response to Far-Right Speech

Emotional contagion: the automatic baseline

- Interaction partners mimic each other's expressions in words, face, voice, and movement.
- Mimicry preserves valence: negative begets negative, positive begets positive.

Boundary drawing

- MPs mark a line against the far right, above all through [anger](#).
- MPs reinforce the signal non-verbally.

Three Mechanisms Shape the Response to Far-Right Speech

Emotional contagion: the automatic baseline

- Interaction partners mimic each other's expressions in words, face, voice, and movement.
- Mimicry preserves valence: negative begets negative, positive begets positive.

Boundary drawing

- MPs mark a line against the far right, above all through [anger](#).
- MPs reinforce the signal non-verbally.

Competition for attention

- Intense delivery makes a statement stand out in the chamber.
- Intense signals travel more easily into media and social media coverage.

Hypotheses for Verbal Communication

H1: Average emotional distancing

Aggregated across speeches and time, established parties respond to AfD presence with more positive emotional language.

Hypotheses for Verbal Communication

H1: Average emotional distancing

Aggregated across speeches and time, established parties respond to AfD presence with more positive emotional language.

H2: Emotions after the far right

Within debates, speeches after the far right carry more negative emotional language, concentrated in anger, than speeches before it.

Hypotheses for Verbal Communication

H1: Average emotional distancing

Aggregated across speeches and time, established parties respond to AfD presence with more positive emotional language.

H2: Emotions after the far right

Within debates, speeches after the far right carry more negative emotional language, concentrated in anger, than speeches before it.

H3: Emotion-specific textual coupling

Responses mirror the actual emotional content of the AfD speech, direction-consistent across the emotional spectrum.

H4: Sequential non-verbal activation

AfD speeches activate other MPs

H4: Sequential non-verbal activation

AfD speeches activate other MPs

- a) across the combined signals: vocal pitch, head movement, audience interaction;

H4: Sequential non-verbal activation

AfD speeches activate other MPs

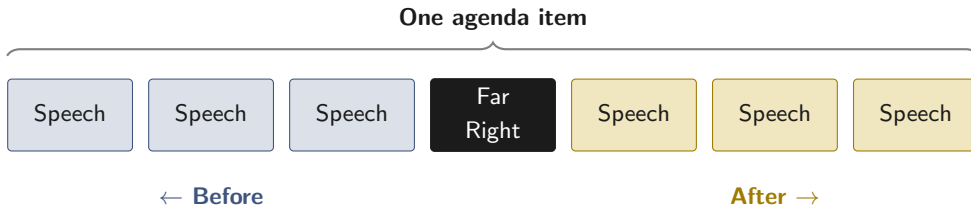
- a) across the combined signals: vocal pitch, head movement, audience interaction;
- b) depending on the verbal and non-verbal content of the preceding AfD speech;

H4: Sequential non-verbal activation

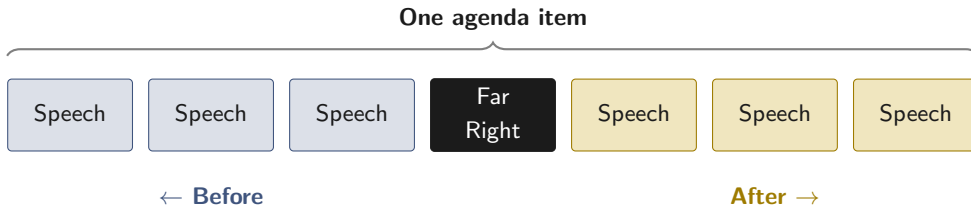
AfD speeches activate other MPs

- a) across the combined signals: vocal pitch, head movement, audience interaction;
- b) depending on the verbal and non-verbal content of the preceding AfD speech;
- c) most strongly when the AfD speech relies heavily on anger.

Research Design: The Same Debate, before and after the AfD



Research Design: The Same Debate, before and after the AfD



The speaker order of the AfD varies across agenda items and parliaments.

The Raw Material: 30,000 Hours of (Very Wild) Parliamentary Video Data

30,000+

hours of video

170,000

raw video files

20 TB

of data

17

parliaments

The Bundestag and all 16 state parliaments

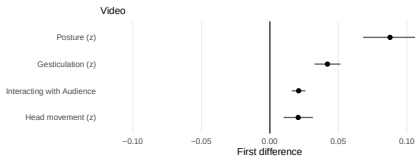
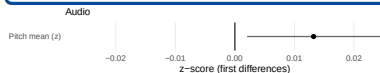
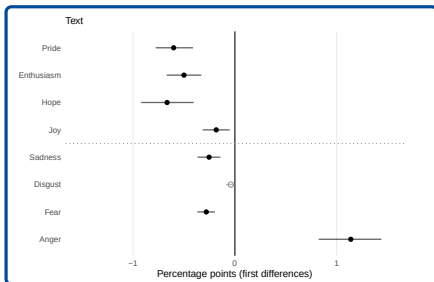
So far: 12/17 Parliaments

Parliament	Years	AfD from	Speeches (with AfD)
Baden-Württemberg	2016–2025	2016	5,818
Bavaria	2018–2025	2018	6,587
Berlin	2020–2025	2016	1,868
Brandenburg	2020–2024	2014	3,271
Hamburg	2017–2024	2015	5,871
Hesse	2017–2025	2019	5,921
Lower Saxony	2022–2025	2017	978
Saarland	2018–2024	2017	2,173
Saxony	2019–2024	2014	5,287
Saxony-Anhalt	2021–2024	2016	3,805
Thuringia	2020–2024	2014	4,118
Bundestag	2017–2025	2017	24,943
Total			70,640

H1: On Average, Established Parties Go High



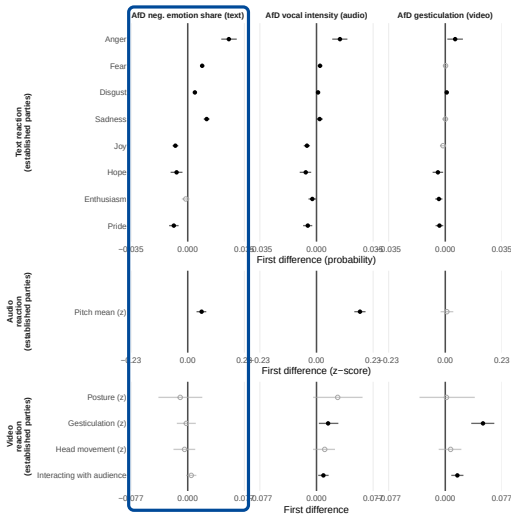
H2: How Does an AfD Speech Change a Debate?



Findings

- No generalised negativity
- Clear effect for **anger**
- Boundary drawing

H3: How Does the Content of an AfD Speech Change a Debate?



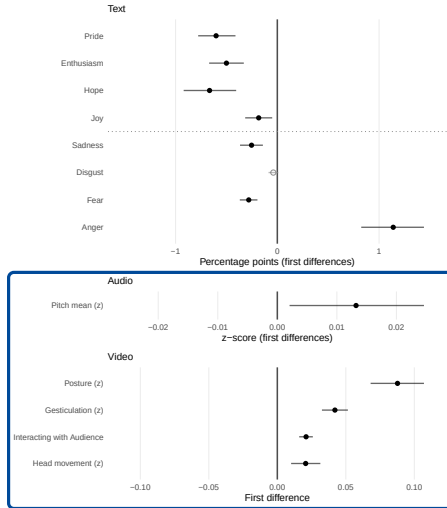
Findings: AfD avg. neg. emotion share

- More negative AfD speech → more negative response, above all **anger**

Findings: AfD vocal intensity

- More vocal intensity

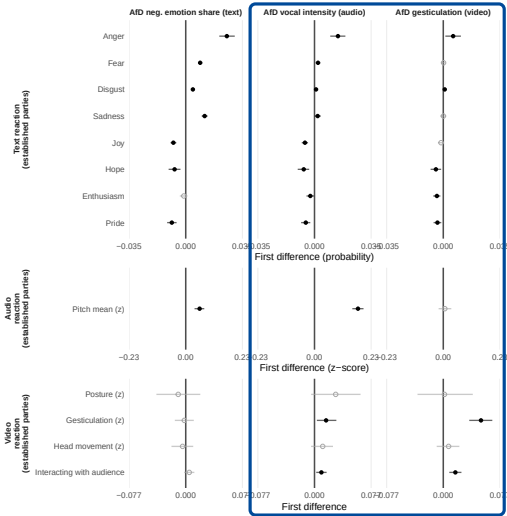
H4a: How Does an AfD Speech Affect Non-Verbal Responses?



Findings: Non-verbal activation

- Non-AfD MPs show more expansive body language and a higher tone

H4b: How Does AfD Non-Verbal Intensity Affect MPs' Responses?



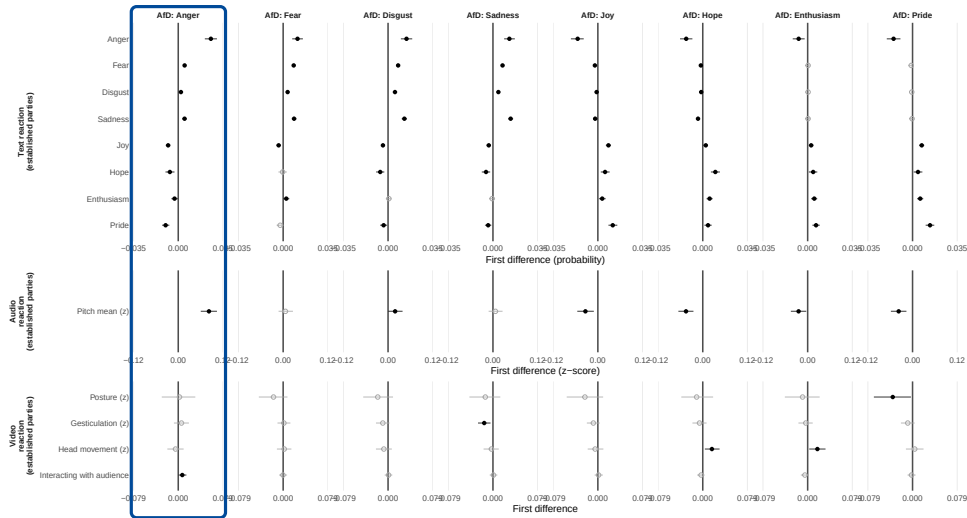
Findings: Vocally intense AfD speech

- Boundary drawing: verbal and non-verbal communication
- Distinct reactions in **anger** and pitch

Findings: High AfD gesticulation

- Boundary drawing
- Effects in **anger**, gesticulation and audience interaction

H4c: What Happens When the AfD Speech Is Distinctly Angry?



Key findings

1. The effect of far-right presence depends on the level of analysis: distancing in the average, anger-led mirroring in the sequence.
2. Activation travels as a broad affective state across voice and body. Text alone cannot see it, and no single channel carries it.
3. Emotional transmission is emotion-specific: it is **anger**, not negativity in general, that moves parliament.

Key findings

1. The effect of far-right presence depends on the level of analysis: distancing in the average, anger-led mirroring in the sequence.
2. Activation travels as a broad affective state across voice and body. Text alone cannot see it, and no single channel carries it.
3. Emotional transmission is emotion-specific: it is **anger**, not negativity in general, that moves parliament.

Do non-AfD MPs go high or low?

- MPs go high on average.
- But they are madly in **anger** when reacting to the AfD.

Far-Right Speeches and Emotional Contagion in Parliament: Sequential and Multimodal Evidence from Germany

Christian Arnold

Andreas Kuepfer

Christian Stecker

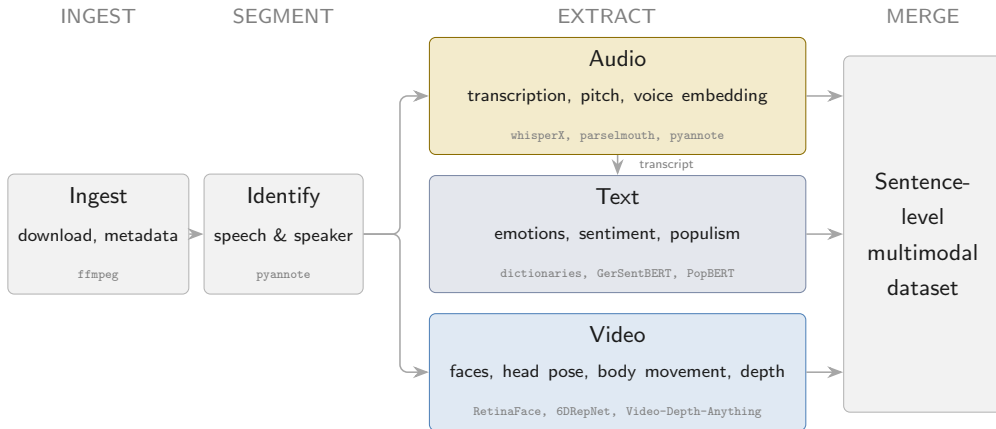
c.arnold.2@bham.ac.uk

andreas.kuepfer@tu-darmstadt.de

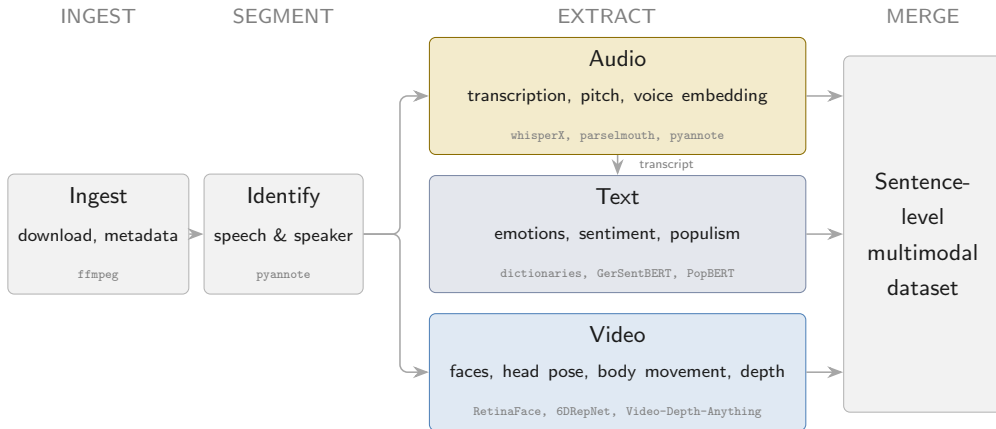
christian.stecker@tu-darmstadt.de

Appendix

Snakemake Pipeline to Turn Video into Data (Kuepfer and Arnold 2026)



Snakemake Pipeline to Turn Video into Data (Kuepfer and Arnold 2026)



One hour of raw video → all features in **under 5 minutes**.

Our Key Variables Here (Aligned at Sentence Level)

Audio

- Deviation from MP average vocal pitch mean (z-score)

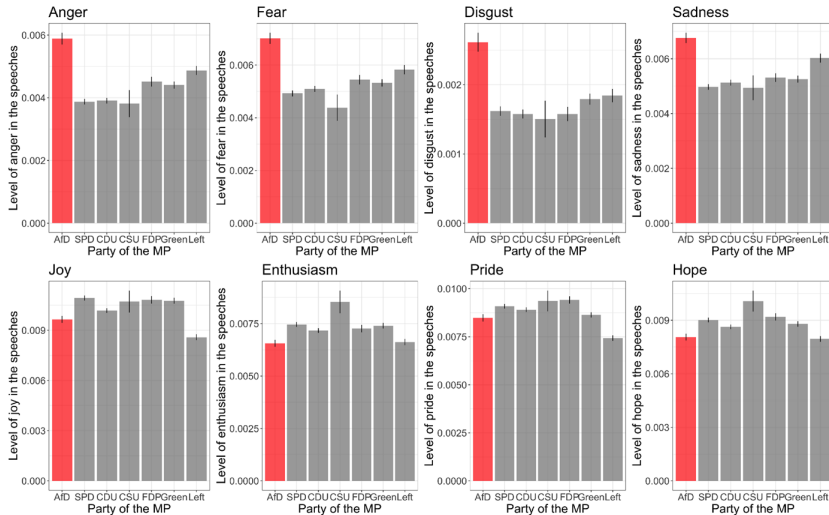
Text

- 4 positive emotions
pride, enthusiasm,
hope, joy (Valentim
and Widmann 2021)
- 4 negative emotions
sadness, disgust, fear,
anger (Valentim and
Widmann 2021)

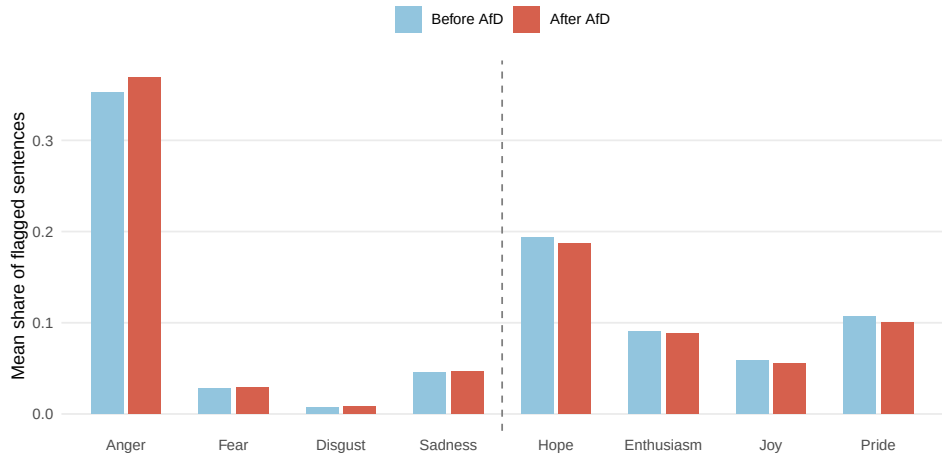
Video

- Head movement: Euclidean norm
of SD across yaw, pitch & roll
- Audience interaction: head is up
(pitch angle)
- Gesticulation: dynamic use of
hand movement (Rittmann 2024)
- Posture: expansive,
body-size-increasing arm
positions (Rittmann 2024)

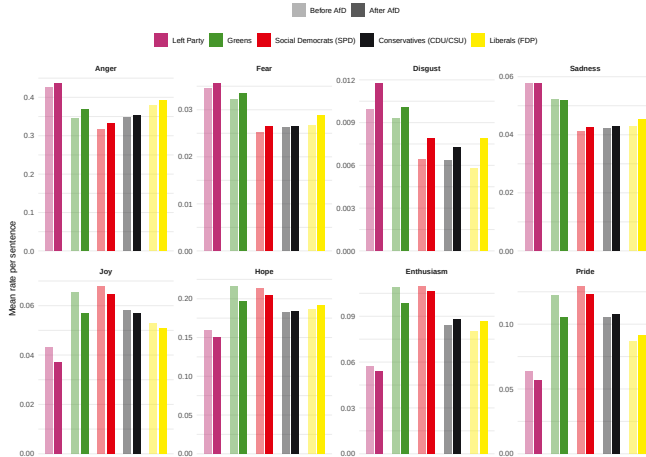
H1: On Average, Established Parties Go High (Valentim and Widmann 2021)



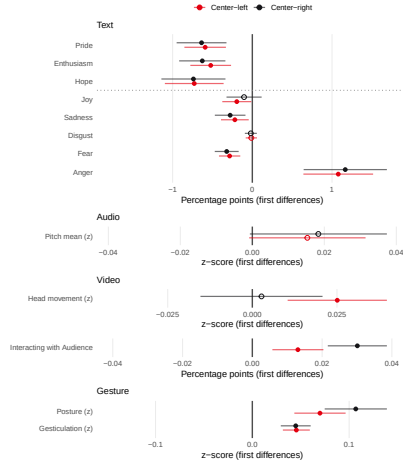
Descriptive Before vs after AfD Speeches



The Pattern Is Not Driven by a Single Party



Responses by Government and Opposition Bloc



- All agenda items in which the AfD held at least one speech, and all speeches within those items after preprocessing
- Excluded: speeches shorter than 2 minutes or longer than 15 minutes
- Excluded: speeches by presidium members (president and vice-presidents)
- Unit of analysis: the sentence, inheriting speaker, party, parliament, agenda item, and before/after position
- Remaining eight state parliaments are currently being annotated; the final dataset covers all 17 chambers

Non-Verbal Measurement

- **Vocal pitch**: sentence-level pitch mean, speaker-centred and z-scored: how far a voice rises above its habitual level
- **Head movement**: within-speech variability of yaw, pitch, and roll angles
- **Audience interaction**: share of sentences in which the speaker looks up from the notes and engages the chamber
- **Gesticulation**: dynamic use of hand movement
- **Posture**: expansive, body-size-increasing arm positions

Caveat: Gesticulation Moderator

- The gesticulation-moderator models currently use the Bundestag and Hesse only
- Pattern mirrors the vocal-intensity results on a smaller scale: more gesticulation, modest pitch increase, more audience interaction; posture and head movement show no clear response
- In the text: anger up, hope and pride down